

But Dr. Ramdas Pai saw something else—a door hidden in the dark.
When he gathered his team, his words were disarmingly simple: "If they can't come to Manipal, Manipal must go to them."
This wasn't expansion. This was imagination unshackled.

Within a few years—years when private colleges in India barely understood the word "internationalisation"—Manipal began doing the unthinkable.
- A collaborative programme in Malaysia.
- A foothold in the West Indies.
- A full-fledged multi-disciplinary campus in Dubai—the first Indian university campus to claim such a space.
- Higher education institutions in Nepal, Oman and Antigua.

This was not slow diplomacy or hesitant outreach; it was a leap. A bet placed on an India not yet ready to believe in itself.

In the words of an administrator who accompanied him on countless missions abroad: "We were walking into territories where Indian education had never been. There were no precedents. But Dr. Pai behaved as though the road existed."

He spoke softly, but he acted with an almost unnerving certainty.

The Art of Moving Without Noise

Unlike flamboyant institution-builders who crave microphones, Dr. Pai was a man of deliberate understatement. If he was proud of something, he hid it behind an affectionate half-smile. If something annoyed him, you'd never know until you noticed that he'd quietly fixed it himself.

A veteran doctor who rose under his leadership once recalled: "He never made you feel like an employee. He sat with you—never above you. There was no high-handedness, no sense of hierarchy. Zero interference, but absolute clarity."

This was the paradox at the heart of Manipal's transformation: an empire built by a man allergic to the performance of power.

He walked into his junior colleagues' offices unannounced. He insisted they have tea before discussing anything serious. He was at events before time—not punctuality, but respect. He listened longer than he spoke.
In an era where institutions were built with authority, Dr. Pai built with humanness. People followed him not because he demanded it, but because something in him made them believe in the improbable.

The Big Bang Moment — 1993

Ask anyone who lived through those years, and they will point to a single moment when Manipal shifted from an ambitious group of institutions into a national force: the day MAHE was granted Deemed University status.

It was 1993. Liberalisation had just begun reshaping India. The country was cautiously finding its feet. And a small town in coastal Karnataka rewrote its destiny.
To the outside world, this was a regulatory milestone. To those inside, it was the moment "Manipal" stopped being a pin on the map and began becoming a global brand.

On the day the recognition came through, Dr. Ramdas Pai is said to have walked into the office with the quietest smile. When congratulated, he shrugged almost dismissively and said: "This is the team's achievement."
He would repeat the same line years later when awarded the Padma Bhushan and the Malaysian Datuk honour. "It is not mine. It belongs to Manipal."
It was not humility. It was his compass.

A University Without Borders — Decades Before It Became Policy

India talks today of building global universities. IIT campuses abroad. International dual degrees. Cross-border teaching.

The NEP 2020 calls it the "internationalisation of Indian education."

But the idea is not new. Its prototype was built quietly, brick by brick, by a man who rarely raised his voice.

Every Manipal campus abroad became a laboratory for a future India had not yet imagined:
- Dubai, where the Manipal name first signalled Indian educational credibility in West Asia.
- Malaysia, where collaborative programmes opened Indian classrooms to Southeast Asia.

MOU signing to establish a medical college between Manipal and Melaka, Malaysia in 1993 in presence of both Prime Ministers -India and Malaysia.



